

We will win

COVID-19 IS A DISASTROUS DISEASE THAT'S SET TO CHANGE THE WORLD FOREVER but you have to give it credit where it's due. This one disease has managed to bring all of humanity together to fight the good fight. And technology's been a major part of it all and will be the key reason why Covid-19 isn't going to be analogous to the Spanish Flu or the Black Plague. Every single popular web service including all the major social media platforms on the planet has a dedicated information page or redirects you to the nearest reliable source of information. By this point you have been bombarded with the same information enough times for you to recite all the symptoms and preventive measures by heart even if you were woken up from a deep slumber.

Most folks are following the norms of **s o c i a l d i s t a n c i n g** because of this information overload. This issue, for one, was mostly written from our homes. Usually when there's a drastic change in the workplace environment, there's a significant drop in productivity. That's not the case this time as we spent the exact same time working on this issue as we did on the previous ones which were produced from our office. The internet infrastructure is supposedly having a tough time keeping up with the surge in traffic as all the intensive work has shifted from enterprise leased lines to residential networks that were never designed to handle such workloads.

While existing technologies have helped us make a smooth transition to working from home, the technology companies which are responsible for the same technologies have been focusing their energies towards mitigating Covid-19's impact. Many companies have come forth to design and produce ventilators and other healthcare equipment on the same assembly lines that were manufacturing cars and batteries just two weeks ago. And it's not just producing new hardware but even the existing ones are being put to good use. Thermal cameras with high resolution and a wide field of view are being deployed to survey crowds in places such as airports. You don't have to form long queues and wait your turn to have a laser thermometer pointed at your fore-

head as the last corridor you walked through had an IR camera doing just that. And if not the camera, perhaps the drone that flew over you when you stepped out might have noted your temperature.

Driverless cars are being deployed to perform contactless deliveries in hospitals which are dealing with the outbreak. Companies such as Tencent have rolled out new functions in their search engine that enables people to search for communities where the infection has been confirmed. State intelligence agencies have also been doing their part. If you are from Israel, then Shin Bet, the security agency has been tracking your phone for a while. If any of the folks who have been shown to be in your vicinity are found to be infected, then Shin Bet's database will allow them to perform contact tracing and isolate everyone that the infected person has been around, at a pace that is way faster than anything else.

Then there's the humble desktop PC. Yes, that PC, the one which has been losing market share and is being declared less significant by the likes of those who side with mobile devices. Hundreds of thousands of these insignificant desktop PCs from the world over have pooled together to form the world's most powerful supercomputer. Folding@Home, the pool towards which all the GPUs within these machines contribute their compute time, has more than one exaflop of compute power. That's a billion billion calculations per second. The nearest multi-million dollar supercomputer is barely capable of hitting 15% of what Folding@Home can perform right now. And most of that is going towards helping researchers understand how to target and defeat 2019-nCoV. And they said the PC is dead. That same 'dead' PC is being used to help people work from home, to keep kids entertained with fascinating learning experiences or equally enjoyable gaming experiences. The humble home PC is what was used by all of us to create this magazine and all of the videos and stories we've written on digit.in. It was also used to create the new digital magazine that you should check out by going to geek.digit.in (if you're not reading this on that already!) 



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